

OWNER STORIES • INTERVIEW SCRIPTS

Built in Lompoc



Local owners, on camera, one question at a time. Every answer becomes a 60-second short. This is the shoot plan, the interviewing rules, the four episode scripts, and who to sit down with first.

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A Lompoc Locals series: local business owners, on camera, answering one question at a time. Every answer becomes a ~60-second short (TikTok / Reel / FB Reel / Story). One 25-minute sit-down = 6–8 shorts + one long cut.

Working title: **Built in Lompoc**. (Alternatives if it doesn't land: *Behind the Counter*, *Owner Stories*.) Keep the name on every cover and end card so the series is recognizable.

Why this works for the platform: members get premium content made from their own words (their assets, our footage — nothing borrowed), locals get real people instead of ads, and every short ends on the member's Lompoc Locals page. It's the spotlight format, told by the owner.

1. The 60-second short — the shape every clip follows

Time	What's on screen	Notes
0–2s	The hook line — their strongest sentence, mid-thought, no intro	Pulled from later in the answer. This decides if anyone watches.
2–5s	Title card: Q: <the question> + lower third: <i>First name</i> · <i>Business</i> · <i>since YEAR</i>	The question is asked by you off-camera AND shown as text.
5–48s	The answer, jump-cut tight. B-roll of their hands/shop over the slow parts.	Cut every pause. Keep their "ums" only where it's charming.
48–56s	The payoff — the lesson or the line that lands	Ask for it explicitly (see §3, "close the loop").
56–60s	End card: Built in Lompoc · Lompoc Locals · <a href="https://lompoclocals.com/biz/<slug>">lompoclocals.com/biz/<slug>	Spoken CTA optional: "More owners at Lompoc Locals."

Rules of thumb: one question per short, never two. Under 60s for TikTok/Reels; 45s is better than 60s. Captions burned in (most people watch muted). Faces at eye-line, vertical 9:16.

2. The shoot (25 minutes, one phone)

Kit: phone in vertical, tripod or propped at eye level, 1 m from them; a lav mic or a second phone as a recorder in their shirt pocket (phone mic from 1 m is the #1 thing that ruins these); face toward a window, never with the window behind them. Record 4K/30 so you can punch in.

Setup (5 min): put them in their space — behind the counter, in the bay, at the bench. The shop is the set. Tell them: "Say the question back in your answer, tell me stories, not opinions, and if you want to redo something just start the sentence again."

Consent (30 s, on camera, before question 1): "Can you tell me your name, your business, and that you're OK with Lompoc Locals sharing this on social media and on our site?" That clip is the release. Keep it in the raw folder forever.

Interview (15 min): one episode script from §4 (6–8 questions) + the rapid-fire closer.

B-roll (5 min, shoot AFTER the interview, when you know which answers you'll use):

1. Hands doing the work (the shot you'll use most)
2. The sign / storefront, slow push-in
3. Them walking in / opening up
4. The detail only they'd notice (the first dollar, the old photo, the tool they've had 20 years)
5. A customer interaction if one happens (ask the customer first)
6. Them laughing / listening — reaction shots to cover jump cuts

Folder: `content/social/video/owner-stories/<slug>/raw/` — interview, consent, b-roll, the question list you actually asked.

3. How to interview (the part that makes or breaks it)

- **Stories, not opinions.** Never "what do you think about...". Always "tell me about the day...", "walk me through the first week", "what happened next".
- **Follow the emotion, not the list.** If their voice changes, drop your next question and ask "what was that like?" or just "...and?" and stay quiet.
- **Silence is the tool.** After an answer, count to four before speaking. The second half of the answer is usually the good half.
- **Repeat the question in the answer.** Remind them once; it lets the clip stand alone.
- **Close the loop.** When an answer is good, ask for the payoff: "If you had to say that in one sentence, what is it?" That sentence is your hook AND your ending.
- **Get the hook last.** End with: "Finish this sentence for me — *the thing nobody tells you about owning a business in Lompoc is...*". Ask for 2–3 versions.
- **Re-ask without apologizing.** "Say that one more time, just the last part" — every time.
- **Don't perform.** Your voice is off camera; nod, don't "mm-hm" (it ruins the audio).
- **No numbers we can't stand behind.** If they claim a stat ("we've done 10,000 cars"), ask "roughly?" and caption it as they said it ("about 10,000 cars, he says") — never as fact.

4. Episode scripts

Each script = one sit-down. Pick the one that fits the owner. Question is what you say; *follow-ups* are what you use when the answer is short; **hook target** is what you're hoping to walk out with.

Episode A — "How it started" (first interview with anyone)

Intro you say on camera, then cut: "This is Built in Lompoc. Every week, one local owner, one question at a time. Today, [business]."

1. **"What were you doing the year before you opened?"**

Follow: What made you leave that? Who told you not to?

Hook target: the moment they decided.

2. **"Tell me about day one. What actually happened?"**

Follow: First customer? First sale — what was it, how much?

3. **"What did you get completely wrong at the start?"**

Follow: When did you realize? What did it cost you?

Hook target: "I thought _____. I was wrong."

4. **"What's the moment you knew it was going to work?"**

Follow: Where were you? Who did you call?

5. **"What does a good day look like now?"**

Follow: And a bad one?

6. **"Why Lompoc? You could have opened anywhere."**

Follow: What does this town do for a business that other towns don't?

7. **Close the loop:** "If someone in Lompoc is thinking about opening something — one sentence."

8. **Hook last:** "Finish this: *the thing nobody tells you about starting a business is...*"

Episode B — "The hardest year" (owners 5+ years in)

1. **"Which year almost ended it?"**

Follow: What was the actual number / the actual week?

2. **"What did you do the morning after the worst day?"**

Hook target: the specific small action — "I opened anyway."

3. **"Who showed up for you?"**

Follow: A supplier, a customer, a family member — tell me the exact thing they did.

4. **"What did you cut, and what did you refuse to cut?"**

Hook target: "I'd have sold the truck before I let someone go."

5. **"What did that year teach you that you still do every week?"**

6. **"What would you tell the owner who's in that year right now?"**

7. **Close the loop / hook last** as in Episode A.

Episode C — "The craft" (trades, food, makers — the how-it's-done episode)

1. **"Show me the thing you're best at. Talk me through it while you do it."** (shoot this one as B-roll with sound — hands + voice)
2. **"What does a customer never see that you obsess over?"**
Hook target: the invisible standard.
3. **"What's the mistake you see other people in your trade make?"** (keep it about the work, not about named competitors — cut anything that names another business)
4. **"What's the job you're proudest of?"**
Follow: Why that one?
5. **"How did you learn it? Who taught you?"**
6. **"What's changed in the last ten years, and what hasn't?"**
7. **Close the loop:** "How do you know when a job is done right — one sentence."

Episode D — "Lompoc, from behind the counter" (community episode, good for long-timers)

1. **"How long have you been on this street, and what was here before?"**
2. **"Tell me about a regular. No names — just the story."**
Hook target: a customer story that says something about the town.
3. **"What do people from out of town get wrong about Lompoc?"**
4. **"What's the best thing that happened in this room?"**
5. **"Which other local business do you send people to, and why?"** (this one is gold — it tags another member; ask for two)
6. **"What do you want Lompoc to look like in ten years?"**
7. **Close the loop:** "What does 'shop local' actually mean to you — one sentence."

Rapid-fire closer (every episode, 90 seconds, its own short)

Say: "Ten questions, one line each, don't think." Cut with a fast beat under it.

1. Coffee or energy drink?
2. First job ever?
3. Earliest you've ever opened?
4. Latest you've ever closed?
5. One tool you'd save in a fire?
6. Best taco in Lompoc?
7. The word your customers use for you?
8. Cash or card?

9. Song that plays most in the shop?
10. Three words: owning a business is ____.

5. Question bank by type of business

Use these to swap into any episode.

Restaurants / food — What's the dish that pays the rent? · What did you take off the menu and regret? · Tell me about the busiest night you ever had. · What do you eat after close? · Who taught you the recipe you're known for?

Trades / contractors / auto — What's the job that made your reputation? · What's the call you get at 11 PM? · What do you tell a customer when the honest answer is "don't fix it"? · What's the tool you bought that changed the business? · How do you find good people?

Retail / shops — What's the item people drive from out of town for? · What sells that you never expected? · How do you compete with a phone in everyone's pocket? · What's the oldest thing in the store? · Tell me about a gift someone bought here that you still think about.

Services / salons / studios — How many people have sat in that chair? · What do people tell you that they don't tell anyone else? (no details, just the fact of it) · What's the transformation you're proudest of? · How did you get your first 20 clients?

Real estate / professional — Tell me about the first home you sold in Lompoc. · What does a first-time buyer here get wrong? · What's the street you'd bet on? · What's the part of the job nobody sees?

6. The ask — booking the owner

In person, at the counter, is best. Keep it to this:

"We're starting a series on Lompoc Locals — owners telling how they got here, one question at a time. Twenty-five minutes, here in your shop, we bring everything. It goes on our Instagram, TikTok and Facebook and on your page. Would next Tuesday morning work?"

DM / email version (send from hello@, sign *The Lompoc Locals team*, never pitch it as "free"):

Subject: Built in Lompoc — would you sit down with us?

Hi [First name],

We're starting a short video series on Lompoc Locals called *Built in Lompoc*: local owners, in their own space, telling how they got where they are — one question at a time. Each answer becomes a one-minute clip on our Instagram, TikTok and Facebook, and lives on your Lompoc Locals page.

It takes about 25 minutes in your shop; we bring the camera and the questions, you bring the stories. Would a morning next week work — Tuesday or Thursday?

The Lompoc Locals team

Paying members first, always. Ask each owner for one introduction at the end of the shoot — "who else in town should we sit down with?" — that's the pipeline.

7. Who to interview first (paying members, Sep 23 2026)

Owner / business	Episode	The angle to chase
Vargas Jewelers Trophies & Awards	D or B	On H Street since 1974 (verify the year with them on camera). Half a century of Lompoc gifts.
In&Out Tires Lpc	C	Already spotlighted (Sep 21) — warm. The "smog on the monitor" scene as B-roll with sound.
Sweet Baking Co.	A	322 N H St, shares the building with the Florist — shoot both the same morning.
Lompoc Valley Florist	D	Same building; the regular-customer story (weddings, funerals — the whole town passes through).
Paisano's Family Barbershop	A / rapid-fire	Barbers are natural talkers; "how many people have sat in that chair".
Coastal Tint	C	Newest storefront member (Sep 6); the craft episode shoots itself.
Clark Builders, Inc.	B	Biggest local conversion; a contractor's hardest year is a good story.
Empire Real Estate — Maressa	A	First Plus realtor; "first home you sold in Lompoc".
Tacos y Mariscos El Culichi	C	The dish that pays the rent; shoot at the line during prep.
Hangar 7 Social House / Jasper's Saloon	D	Ocean Ave and H Street history from behind the bar.
Eddie's Grill	B	Long-timer; hardest year.
Oliveira's Fashion Floors, J's Glass, Valley Embroidery	C	Trades with visual work — hands B-roll.

Rotate: never two owners from the same category back to back, and never the same owner twice within a month.

8. Post — cut sheet, captions, publishing

Naming: owner-stories/<slug>/<n>-<question-slug>.mp4 (e.g. vargas/03-got-wrong.mp4).

Cut: follow §1. Jump cuts are fine; cover the ugliest one with B-roll. Lower third on the first frame they appear. Question card set in the brand type (purple #650C75 on cream, gold #EFC618 rule). Captions in the kit's caption band (safe zone, CAPTION_BAND_PCT). Music: a low bed under the story clips at -22 LUFS or none at all; the rapid-fire gets a fast beat. New bed per clip, generated — never a licensed track.

Cover: frame 0 = their face, mid-sentence, with the hook line as text. Judge it in the centre-square crop.

Caption template (IG / FB):

"<the hook line>" — <First name>, <Business>, Lompoc.

Built in Lompoc, episode <n>: <one line on what they answered>.

<Business> · <address> · <phone if they want it>

Their page: lompoclocals.com/biz/<slug>

#Lompoc #LompocLocals #BuiltInLompoc #ShopLocal #<category tag> #CentralCoast

TikTok gets the video and the hook line only; the page link goes in the first comment. IG Story: the clip + link sticker "Meet <First name>" → their page (utm ig-story , campaign built-in-lompoc-<slug>). Post in the 6–8 PM window; one owner's clips spread over a week (Mon story clip, Wed craft clip, Fri rapid-fire), not dumped in a day.

Before anything posts: the owner watches the cut; anything about a named third party, a number we can't source, or a health/legal claim comes out.

Track: log each clip in content/social/posts/<date>-owner-<slug>.md like a spotlight (Buffer ids, live links, first-24h metrics) and note which question produced the best watch time — after 5 owners, the question list gets rewritten from that data.